

Dance of the Happy Shades



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF ALICE MUNRO

Alice Munro was born in 1931 in Wingham, a small rural town in southwestern Ontario, Canada. Munro started writing as a teenager and published her first story at the age of 19. She studied English literature at the University of Western Ontario for two years. In 1951, she married James Munro. The couple moved to Vancouver, had three daughters, and opened a bookstore in Victoria, British Columbia. After having a fourth daughter, Munro published the short story collection *Dance of the Happy Shades* and the novel *Lives of Girls and Women*. In 1972, Munro and her husband separated, and Munro returned to the University of Western Ontario as a writer in residence. She later married Gerald Fremlin and moved to Clinton, Ontario. Throughout her career, Munro has published 13 short story collections, many of which are set in the same region where she grew up and take inspiration from her life. Her most recent book is the short story collection *Dear Life*, published in 2012. Her writing has appeared in many different periodicals, including *The New Yorker* and *The Paris Review*, and has won international critical acclaim. Munro is widely considered a master of the short story form.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Munro published *Dance of the Happy Shades* during the second-wave feminist movement. This movement was active from the 1960s through the 1980s and fought to achieve greater gender equality. It moved beyond women's suffrage—which was the main focus of first-wave feminism—to challenge more aspects of patriarchal culture and to address issues such as reproductive rights, domestic roles, and workplace inequalities. Even Munro's earliest writing touches on the restrictive social pressures and marginalization that girls and women face in a patriarchal society. In "Dance of the Happy Shades," Miss Marsalles suffers from society's disvaluing of women: her identity as a spinster is stigmatized, she struggles financially because she isn't married, and she's regarded as an outcast even by other women for her childlessness and old age. Munro also writes about children with Down syndrome in "Dance of the Happy Shades." Historically, people with Down syndrome have been mistreated. In Canada in the 1950s, it was common for children with Down syndrome to be separated from their families and placed in inhumane institutions. It wasn't until the 1980s and 1990s that legal and social reforms began to better protect people with Down syndrome from discrimination. Munro's humanizing representation of children with Down syndrome in 1968 offered an empathetic perspective on the

rights of people with Down syndrome before those rights were officially recognized and supported.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Much of Munro's writing, including the short story "Dance of the Happy Shades," follows the conventions of literary realism. This means that her stories deal frankly with ordinary, everyday events, which are often drawn from Munro's own life experiences. Munro also frequently centers girls and women in her stories, imbuing a staunchly feminist perspective in her work. Like "Dance of the Happy Shades," many of the other 14 stories in Munro's anthology *Dance of the Happy Shades* are multilayered, intricate narratives that appear simple at first glance. They also focus on mundane moments in the lives of young girls, middle-aged women, and elderly women that give rise to subtle revelations and showcase the complexities of human relationships. As an author, Munro shares similarities with the Russian short story writer Anton Chekhov, whose stories and writing style influenced her own. Both writers favor realism, prioritize characters' internal emotions and transformations over plot, and use nonlinear narratives. Furthermore, Munro's literary career was influenced by her friend Margaret Laurence, the feminist Canadian short story writer and novelist. Margaret Atwood is another famous Canadian writer whose poems and novels concern the lives of girls and women through a feminist lens and often take place in Southern Ontario.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Dance of the Happy Shades
- **When Published:** 1968
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Short Story, Realism, Southern Ontario Gothic
- **Setting:** Southern Ontario, Canada, around the middle of the 20th century
- **Climax:** Dolores Boyle plays a piano piece called "The Dance of the Happy Shades"
- **Antagonist:** Society's biases against people who live outside the status quo
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Work in Progress. Munro spent 15 years writing the short stories for *Dance of the Happy Shades* before publishing the collection in 1968. The title story, "Dance of the Happy Shades," was one of the later ones she completed. Munro wrote it when she was in her thirties.

Award-Winning. Munro's short story anthology *Dance of the Happy Shades* won the 1968 Governor General's Award for English Fiction. Munro herself won the Man Booker International Prize in 2009 and the Nobel Prize in Literature in 2013.



PLOT SUMMARY

"Dance of the Happy Shades" takes place in southern Ontario, Canada, in the mid-20th century. The narrator is a middle-class teenage girl who takes piano lessons from Miss Marsalles, an elderly music teacher. Miss Marsalles is having another party, or music recital, in June. The narrator's mother—one of Miss Marsalles's former students—doesn't want to attend, so she tries making various excuses. She suggests that Miss Marsalles shouldn't have the party at all because she's too old and because the older Marsalles sister has recently had a stroke. However, Miss Marsalles is too enthusiastic to cancel the party. The narrator's mother regards Miss Marsalles with condescending pity but politely agrees to attend the party. Then the narrator's mother calls her friend on the phone to commiserate about Miss Marsalles's awkward parties.

Overhearing her mother's conversations, the narrator considers her own memories of Miss Marsalles's annual festivities. The parties have become uncomfortable lately because fewer people are attending them, which worries the narrator's mother. All Miss Marsalles cares about, though, is teaching music to children. The narrator remembers that, in the past, Miss Marsalles's parties weren't bad. The **food** was good, the students' performances were lackluster but usually not disastrous, and the whole event was reliably consistent. Miss Marsalles always looked the same, "kindly and grotesque," dressed in an old-fashioned style. Year after year, Miss Marsalles's lifestyle has persisted without change. She maintains old traditions—such as giving gifts to her pupils at recitals—even when she likely can no longer afford them.

On the day of Miss Marsalles's party, the narrator and her mother reluctantly arrive at the small half-house on Bala Street, where Miss Marsalles merrily waits to greet them. Curiously, Miss Marsalles seems to be expecting more arrivals. Inside the house, there are only a few other party guests. The narrator's mother is upset that her friend hasn't come but tries to act pleasant. She speaks to Mrs. Clegg, Miss Marsalles's neighbor, about the older Marsalles sister, who is bedridden upstairs and not doing well. The narrator's mother suddenly notices that flies are crawling all over the food Miss Marsalles prepared. The narrator's mother grows dismayed but stops Mrs. Clegg from impolitely gossiping about their hostess.

Finally, the younger children start to perform. Miss Marsalles and Mrs. Clegg encourage them with enthusiastic applause, while the uneasy mothers are relieved that the recital is

nearing its end. While the narrator performs, a new group of children arrive, startling everyone except for Miss Marsalles. Miss Marsalles welcomes them, but the other women now appear to feel trapped and offended. The newly arrived children are Miss Marsalles's pupils from Greenhill School, and they have Down syndrome. The women's distress increases as each of these children also performs. Then a girl named Dolores Boyle skillfully plays a beautiful, cheerful piece of music. The mothers are caught in a "profound anxiety," but Miss Marsalles is as happy with Dolores as with any of her other students. She doesn't view Dolores's musicality as an extraordinary miracle or an affront to propriety; instead, she celebrates Dolores's talent as an ordinary joy. When Dolores's performance is over, the narrator observes that the women are troubled. They view Dolores's ability as "useless" and "out-of-place" because she has Down syndrome. Desperately trying to remain polite, however, they ask what the piece she played is called. Miss Marsalles answers that it is called **The Dance of the Happy Shades**.

On her way home from Miss Marsalles's house, where she will never attend another party, the narrator realizes she can't pity Miss Marsalles as she expected to. "The Dance of the Happy Shades"—as a "communiqué from the other country" in which Miss Marsalles seems to exist—has taught her that Miss Marsalles isn't to be pitied.



CHARACTERS

The Narrator – The unnamed narrator is a teenage girl from a middle-class family that lives in the suburbs of southern Ontario, Canada. She takes piano lessons from Miss Marsalles, the same music teacher who once taught her mother. Throughout the story, she recalls memories of Miss Marsalles, reflects on her mother's relationship to the music teacher, and pays careful attention to the people and events unfolding around her. The narrator's astute observations about her mother, Miss Marsalles, and Miss Marsalles's party seem detached and objective. She seems to understand her mother well, which enables her to make intelligent inferences about her mother's emotions. She's attentive to small details and sensitive to social cues that indicate how other people are thinking and feeling, even if they're attempting to hide their true thoughts and feelings behind polite exteriors. The narrator's social awareness makes her an insightful narrator. However, she isn't completely objective. She reveals her own biases implicitly through her descriptions. For instance, she sees her music teacher as ugly, grotesque, bizarre, and pathetic. Like her mother, she is inclined to pity and look down on Miss Marsalles. Her mother's influence is also evident in the narrator's already thorough understanding of social norms and her belief in their importance. And yet, the narrator diverges from her mother's way of thinking, especially at the end of the story, realizing that

her mother's intolerance and prejudice against the Greenhill School children isn't right. At the same time, she recognizes that Miss Marsalles is more empathetic than her own mother. In the end, the narrator undergoes a subtle, transformative realization. She understands that her former assumption that she and her mother are superior to the pitiable Miss Marsalles was wrong, and she changes her perspective.

Miss Marsalles – Miss Marsalles is an elderly music teacher who gives piano lessons to children. Years ago, she taught the narrator's mother to play piano. Now, she's the young narrator's music teacher. Miss Marsalles isn't married and doesn't have children. She resides with her older sister in a small half-house on Bala Street, because they can no longer afford to live in their family home or the small bungalow on Bank Street. In spite of her sister's ill-health and their impoverishment, Miss Marsalles is cheerful and social. She enjoys hosting parties, so she holds a music recital every June. Hearing her students perform brings her great joy. She is affectionate and tenderhearted toward children, believing that their hearts naturally love all good things. She rarely criticizes her young students and always gives them gifts at recitals. Additionally, Miss Marsalles is old-fashioned, and her lifestyle never seems to change. Her clothes, the decorations in her home, and the rituals of her annual parties remain consistent year after year. She seems ignorant of—or unaffected by—modern fashions and how other people perceive her. She is oblivious to the way other people, including the narrator's mother, pity and infantilize her for being an old, sentimental spinster. Despite growing older, struggling financially, caring for her unwell sister, and being treated as inferior by other women, Miss Marsalles is persistently happy. Introducing music into children's lives fulfills her. At the party, she celebrates all her students with kindness, empathy, and acceptance. Miss Marsalles recognizes and rejoices in small, everyday miracles, which add meaning to her life as she embraces them.

The Narrator's Mother – The narrator's mother is a middle-class woman who took piano lessons from Miss Marsalles in her youth and now has her own daughter—the narrator—who takes lessons from Miss Marsalles, too. The narrator's mother is highly conscious of social etiquette and concerned about what is socially proper, respectable, and polite. Since moving to the suburbs, she worries she'll fall behind current fashions. She doesn't enjoy attending Miss Marsalles's annual parties because they're awkward, tedious, and uncomfortably embarrassing. She also pities Miss Marsalles and feels superior to the elderly spinster instead of genuinely caring for her. When the narrator's mother is invited to this year's June recital, she dreads the event and tries to lie and make up excuses against attending. But, out of politeness, she agrees to go. At the party, she puts on a false appearance, pretending to enjoy herself. She suffers discomfort at Mrs. Clegg's inconsiderate gossip and the poor state of the **food**. She

doesn't find pleasure in listening to the children's performances and grows outraged when a new group of children arrives from Greenhill School. These children, who are more of Miss Marsalles's students, have Down syndrome. The narrator's mother believes that their presence goes against propriety because their differences make them unfit for polite society. Her prejudice about who does and doesn't belong in society prevents her from fully appreciating Dolores Boyle's beautiful playing. She rejects both the music and the happiness it could bring her. The narrator's mother's preoccupation with politeness thus discourages her from being genuine, hinders her from experiencing joy and valuable human connection, and causes her to treat other people with little empathy or kindness.

Mrs. Clegg – Mrs. Clegg, a middle-aged woman, is the Marsalles sisters' neighbor. She attends Miss Marsalles's party because she likes music and was invited to hear the children perform. In some ways, Mrs. Clegg presents a pleasant exterior. She wears a freshly laundered dress to the recital, and she's supportive of the children's performances, demonstrating this with enthusiastic applause. But, in other ways, Mrs. Clegg is clearly unpleasant. A bad odor clings to her, and she lacks true kindness and empathy. She's eager to gossip about the misfortunes of the Marsalles sisters without sensitivity or concern for their privacy. She pities and infantilizes the older women, viewing them as babies who require charity. And she delights in Miss Marsalles's mistake of putting the **food** out too early, which allows her to feel superior to the elderly music teacher and to relish the drama of the narrator's mother's dismay. Mrs. Clegg's lack of empathy is also evident in how she talks about Miss Marsalles's students who have Down syndrome. She others them by emphasizing their differences from "normal" children, by infantilizing them, and by treating them as inferior. Mrs. Clegg is as narrow-minded as the narrator's mother, but she exhibits her biases more plainly because she isn't as concerned with social etiquette.

Dolores Boyle – Dolores Boyle is a tall, blonde, slender girl who is one of Miss Marsalles's students. She was born with Down syndrome, and she attends Greenhill School with other children who also have Down syndrome. At Miss Marsalles's party, she skillfully performs a piano piece called **The Dance of the Happy Shades**. She captures everyone's attention with her beautiful musicality.

Miss Marsalles's Sister – Miss Marsalles's older sister is an elderly, unmarried, and childless woman. She's a retired teacher who used to give private lessons in French and German. Recently, however, she suffered a stroke. Now she is bedridden and unable to speak. The younger Miss Marsalles and the neighboring Mrs. Clegg take care of her, but she spends most of her time alone in an upstairs room of the house.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



SOCIAL ETIQUETTE AND POLITENESS

In “Dance of the Happy Shades,” a story set in southern Ontario during the mid-20th century, a teenage girl—the narrator—and her mother struggle with their discomfort at an awkward party thrown by the elderly music teacher, Miss Marsalles. The girl’s mother places great importance on social etiquette. As a result, even though she dreads the annual music recital, she politely agrees to attend the event and tries to hide her unease with outward politeness. Clinging desperately to her idea of good manners, she refuses to engage in the “impropriety” of gossiping about Miss Marsalles, attempts to maintain a pleasant facade, and suffers embarrassment at Miss Marsalles’s seeming lack of social awareness.

Broadly speaking, the purpose of being polite is to avoid offense and to show respect, but “Dance of the Happy Shades” reveals the limitations of this form of social etiquette. Crucially, the story illustrates that being polite is not the same as being kind. Being polite doesn’t prevent the teenage girl’s mother from looking down on Miss Marsalles with condescending pity. She judges Miss Marsalles for her old age, old-fashioned ways, and ignorance of her guests’ tastes. Being overly concerned about appearances, fashionability, and manners prevents her from viewing Miss Marsalles with sympathy or trying to understand her perspective.

Moreover, the story suggests that politeness upholds the status quo to the detriment of anyone who doesn’t or can’t fit into it. Rules of politeness ostracize certain people from society because they’re different. This is the case for Miss Marsalles’s newest students, who are children with Down syndrome. At the party, the mothers are scandalized by the presence of these children, which they view as an affront to politeness. They deem the musical ability of one of these girls, Dolores Boyle, “not altogether *in good taste*” because she has an intellectual and developmental disability. However, it’s clear that the mothers’ prejudice is offensive, even as they try to disguise their disgust with so-called politeness. In “Dance of the Happy Shades,” then, Munro suggests that a superficial preoccupation with politeness can actually enable people to move through the world with a certain lack of empathy, as enforcing rules of politeness often harmfully excludes some people—who are wrongfully deemed unworthy of respect because of their differences—from society. Rather than politeness, the story

indicates, compassion and empathy are more beneficial values to pursue because they can foster genuine human connection.



PREJUDICE, OTHERNESS, AND OSTRACIZATION

“Dance of the Happy Shades” is ultimately about people who are othered by their society. Miss

Marsalles and her sister are two such people. Both women are unmarried and childless, contrary to societal norms for women. Moreover, their old age sets them apart from the younger, modern women; the elderly sisters seem to belong to a distant, antiquated past. Combined, these factors lead to the Marsalles sisters’ isolation from society. Their shared impoverishment and the declining health of Miss Marsalles’s older sister must also intensify Miss Marsalles’s loneliness. Other people pity the Marsalles sisters but do little to help or connect with them beyond a superficial level. In other words, they don’t sincerely care about the sisters.

Instead, they try to distance themselves, made uncomfortable by the sisters’ differences. Other women condemn the sisters for being ugly and grotesque, infantilize them by calling them babies, and they treat them as if they exist outside the world of “normal” people. Similarly, the children from Greenhill School are also othered by society. Because they have Down syndrome, they’re ostracized and seen as “abnormal.” The mothers at Miss Marsalles’s party are repulsed by the children’s differences and offended by their presence. They believe it’s polite to ignore the existence of these children rather than acknowledge them, and they think musicality is “useless” and “out-of-place” for children with disabilities. In fact, the children are effectively dehumanized by everyone except Miss Marsalles, who is herself othered by society. Indeed, Miss Marsalles is the only person in the story who treats the children with Down syndrome with any sort of kindness, as she seems to hold no prejudices against them. Furthermore, she treats everyone at her party equally and expresses the same amount of joy about all of her pupils’ performances. She’s neither shocked nor upset that Dolores Boyle, a girl with Down syndrome, plays the piano beautifully. Instead, she’s as happy with Dolores as with any of her students. By highlighting this dynamic, “Dance of the Happy Shades” illustrates the hurtful isolation and ostracization that some people in society undergo and, most importantly, refutes the notion that anyone should be shunned or kept invisible, instead encouraging a spirit of empathy and acceptance.



SOCIETAL EXPECTATIONS VS. SELF-FULFILLMENT

Miss Marsalles’s life in “Dance of the Happy Shades” is clearly deteriorating, and her surrounding society expects her to act in certain ways that

reflect this. The elderly music teacher and her older sister are aging, and their social prospects, finances, and health are in decline. The Marsalles sisters have moved into a smaller house, and the older sister has recently suffered a stroke, leaving her bedridden and unable to speak. Over the years, the quality of the parties Miss Marsalles hosts has also taken a turn for the worse. Fewer students attend, and the annual social events become increasingly awkward and unpleasant for the guests. The narrator's mother pities Miss Marsalles but also seems to consider the deterioration of her life appropriate for a woman of her position—it's implied that the narrator's mother thinks Miss Marsalles's misfortunes are sad but that they aren't surprising, considering that Miss Marsalles is an old, childless spinster. With this in mind, the narrator's mother thinks Miss Marsalles should act accordingly—for example, Miss Marsalles shouldn't have parties anymore because she's elderly and impoverished. In other words, the narrator's mother believes Miss Marsalles should accept her deteriorating circumstances.

However, Miss Marsalles doesn't submit to the deterioration of her life as a tragic inevitability. She continues to teach piano lessons because she believes music is good for everyone, and she keeps throwing parties because she loves socializing. She decorates her house and dresses herself in the same out-of-date styles, and she carries on the same traditions, such as gift-giving at her recitals, even when she may not have the financial means to sustain them. Miss Marsalles's consistency is so thorough that her former music students, now middle-aged women with their own children, find it incredible and "wholly unrealistic." To these women, including the narrator's mother, Miss Marsalles's stubborn commitment to the usual routine—the one she established years ago—is inappropriate, pathetic, and embarrassing. In their minds, Miss Marsalles should be miserable, and they should pity her.

Yet Miss Marsalles's persistence makes her happy, and her joy itself persists despite her deteriorating circumstances. She draws strength from her unrelenting confidence in goodness and gains satisfaction from continuing to do what brings her joy. In doing so, she contradicts what society expects of her. Miss Marsalles's persistence is not a weakness, nor does it make her pathetic or inferior to the women who look down on her. Through Miss Marsalles, "Dance of the Happy Shades" suggests that firmly following one's own personal fulfillment regardless of stifling societal expectations is a great personal strength and yields more happiness than conforming to narrow social conventions.



DEATH, LIFE, AND JOY

While "Dance of the Happy Shades" doesn't depict death itself, in its beginning the story associates the Marsalles sisters with imagery of death. The older Marsalles sister is a mere shadow, and her ill health after a stroke makes her fragile. The younger Miss Marsalles is elderly,

"grotesque," and separate from the "people who live in the world," as if she isn't a living person but rather a strange ghost from a time long past. Additionally, the flies crawling over the **food** Miss Marsalles sets out for her party signify deterioration and decay, enhancing the impression that the Marsalles sisters themselves represent death. But the end of the story reveals that Miss Marsalles also cultivates joy and a sense of vibrancy. By inviting the children from Greenhill School to her party, she brings in new life and liveliness. By continuing in her teaching role, she nurtures a younger generation and offers them the valuable opportunity to learn music. And by promoting music, she encourages more people to experience music's enlivening and transformative power. The power of music is evident in Dolores Boyle's beautiful performance, which brings vibrant emotions to life, enchants her listeners, and moves through space as though the music itself is alive. Miss Marsalles is able to enjoy Dolores's performance, while the other guests at the recital reject it because of their prejudice. In this way, Miss Marsalles is more connected to the joys of life than the disdainful mothers who negatively judge her and shun Dolores Boyle. Miss Marsalles embraces the profoundness of music and life's beauties in a way that the small-minded women fail to do. She knows that life contains quiet, ordinary miracles, celebrates them contentedly, and fills her existence with meaning. "Dance of the Happy Shades" thus suggests that to truly appreciate life as Miss Marsalles does is to recognize these small wonders, accept them for what they are, and enjoy them.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



FOOD

The food at Miss Marsalles's parties symbolizes Miss Marsalles's her steady, unchanging nature.

Recalling past recitals, the narrator remembers that food has always been an important component of Miss Marsalles's parties, and the food is often the same—sandwiches and ice cream—every year. The food that Miss Marsalles serves her guests is as consistent as the other traditions of her parties, such as the gift-giving ceremony, exemplifying Miss Marsalles's remarkable commitment to tradition. The food also signifies Miss Marsalles's eagerness to take care of her guests. Miss Marsalles persists in her annual traditions and her generosity toward others even when her circumstances in life are deteriorating. At the present-day party in the second half of "Dance of the Happy Shades," she puts out an elaborate spread of food even though she doesn't have the same financial means that she used to have. She still wants to be a good host and provide for her guests. Despite her impoverishment, her

selfless goodwill persists. At the same time, though, the food at her parties used to be appealing to the narrator, but because Miss Marsalles can no longer afford to have somebody else make the food, it is now repulsive—there are flies crawling all over it, and this enhances the narrator and her mother’s feelings of superiority over Miss Marsalles. The poor quality of the food thus comes to symbolize Miss Marsalles’s diminished social value, even if the presence of the food illustrates—on a broader level—Miss Marsalles’s good-natured commitment to providing nice things for her guests.



THE DANCE OF THE HAPPY SHADES

The piano piece that Dolores Boyle performs at Miss Marsalles’s party, called “The Dance of the Happy Shades,” symbolizes unlikely joy. The music itself is unexpectedly joyful. Dolores’s expressive playing carries “the freedom of a great unemotional happiness,” which surprises Dolores’s listeners because they didn’t anticipate such a skillful performance at the dull recital. The music’s title also hints at this idea of unexpected joy—after all, it might seem strange or even impossible for “shades,” or spirits of the dead, to be happy and to dance. Nevertheless, the music’s title declares that the shades are happy, whether or not the living can comprehend this happiness. Importantly, “The Dance of the Happy Shades” is a real piece of music from the opera *Orfeo ed Euridice* by Christoph Gluck, which also illustrates unlikely joy. The opera retells the Ancient Greek myth of Orpheus and Eurydice, in which Orpheus descends into the Underworld to bring his deceased lover back to life. In many versions of the story, Orpheus fails, but Gluck’s opera allows Orpheus and Eurydice to experience unexpected joy in its happy conclusion. Thus, in many ways, the music piece encapsulates the notion of vibrant, undeniable happiness enjoyed by people who, like shades, aren’t ordinarily expected to be happy. Crucially, at the end of Munro’s story, the narrator realizes she can’t pity Miss Marsalles because she recognizes that Miss Marsalles, against all expectation, genuinely happy. The Dance of the Happy Shades—through literal music and the music’s symbolic meaning—has communicated Miss Marsalles’s profound joy, which goes against the expectations of people like the narrator’s mother. That Munro chose to title this short story after “The Dance of the Happy Shades” signifies the central importance of unlikely joy to the narrative as a whole and to Miss Marsalles’s character in particular.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Vintage edition of *Dance of the Happy Shades: And Other Stories* published in 1998.

Dance of the Happy Shades Quotes

☞ [...] she turns her face from the telephone with that look of irritation—as if she had seen something messy which she was unable to clean up—which is her private expression of pity.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles, The Narrator’s Mother

Related Themes:



Page Number: 212

Explanation and Analysis

While talking to Miss Marsalles over the telephone, the narrator’s mother turns away with a “look of irritation.” The narrator comments that this look on her mother’s face is her “private expression of pity.” The narrator’s mother pities Miss Marsalles because she doesn’t think anyone enjoys Miss Marsalles’s parties except for Miss Marsalles herself. Because the narrator knows her mother well, she’s able to offer intelligent insights into her mother’s pity that her mother wouldn’t articulate on her own out of concern for politeness.

The narrator’s specific words in this passage are quite revealing. Her mother’s pity is almost synonymous with irritation, suggesting that this pity isn’t rooted in goodwill but rather in distaste for Miss Marsalles. The narrator’s mother isn’t motivated by her pity to help and support Miss Marsalles; instead, she’s upset by Miss Marsalles and would rather distance herself from her. Furthermore, the narrator suggests that her mother views the object of her pity as “something messy” that she can’t “clean up,” or fix. In other words, the narrator’s mother feels there is something wrong about Miss Marsalles that can’t be made right or acceptable. The narrator’s mother’s pity is unkind and condescending because it grows out of her belief that Miss Marsalles is wrong in some way. Although the narrator’s mother hides her true feelings behind politeness, her attitude toward Miss Marsalles showcases how she sees Miss Marsalles as an unpleasant other with whom she doesn’t want to associate.

☞ It is one of Miss Marsalles’ indestructible beliefs that she can see into children’s hearts, and she finds there a treasury of good intentions and a natural love of all good things. The deceptions which her spinster’s sentimentality has practiced on her original good judgement are legendary and colossal; she has this way of speaking of children’s hearts as if they were something holy; it is hard for a parent to know what to say.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 213

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the narrator reflects on her music teacher, offering insights into Miss Marsalles's beliefs. According to the narrator, Miss Marsalles strongly believes that children are full of "good intentions," which are so valuable and abundant in them that their hearts are metaphorical "treasur[ies]." Miss Marsalles also believes that children innately possess "a natural love" for everything "good." From Miss Marsalles's view of children, it's clear that the elderly music teacher is affectionate and softhearted. She's stubbornly inclined to see goodness and innocence in other people.

Importantly, the portrayal of Miss Marsalles in this passage is not objective. It's filtered through the narrator's eyes, and the narrator is biased against her music teacher. She perceives Miss Marsalles's "sentimentality" as a fault. To the narrator, Miss Marsalles's beliefs are "deceits," or falsehoods, and her "original good judgement" has been distorted to a "colossal" extent. The narrator thinks Miss Marsalles is foolish for harboring such tenderness for children. Moreover, the narrator attributes Miss Marsalles's lack of good judgement to her spinsterhood. By doing so, the narrator perpetuates social stigmas against older unmarried women. Additionally, when the narrator claims that parents don't "know what to say" in response to Miss Marsalles's sentimentality, she implies that Miss Marsalles is so strange that "normal" people can't comprehend or agree with her. The narrator others Miss Marsalles by deeming her beliefs nonsensical and by viewing her as inferior because she's a single older woman.

Page Number: 214

Explanation and Analysis

The narrator portrays the Marsalles sisters as ugly, strange, and incomprehensible in their otherness. Her mingled scorn and fascination toward the Marsalles sisters both contribute to the picture she paints of them as inferior—and even less human—because they don't adhere to social norms for women. First, the narrator suggests that the Marsalles sisters' ugliness marks them as "*impossible*." In other words, the two older women's lack of physical beauty makes it impossible for them to fully participate and be accepted in society. Although the narrator frames the Marsalles sisters' ugliness as "a piece of luck" and "a protection against life," which sound like positive statements, she only alienates the older women by implying that they cannot possibly belong in society the way other women do.

Second, the narrator infantilizes the Marsalles sisters by deeming them simplistically happy and "childish people." In reality, the Marsalles sisters are adult women with their own complexities and hardships; just because they never married or had children doesn't mean they aren't mature.

Third, the narrator dehumanizes Miss Marsalles and her older sister when she calls them "creatures" who are "wild and gentle," "yet domestic." Such language, which is typically applied to animals, shows that the narrator doesn't fully respect the Marsalles sisters as people.

Fourth, and lastly, the narrator claims the elderly sisters exist "outside the complications of time," as if they live in an entirely different world separate from "normal" people. Because the narrator doesn't understand people who don't conform to the status quo, she considers Miss Marsalles and her sister—two elderly spinsters—to be utterly "bizarre." Simultaneously, the narrator wonders at and looks down on them.

●● It must finally have come to seem like a piece of luck to them to be so ugly, a protection against life to be marked in so many ways, *impossible*, for they were gay as invulnerable and childish people are; they appeared sexless, wild and gentle creatures, bizarre yet domestic, living in their house in Rosedale outside the complications of time.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles, Miss Marsalles's Sister

Related Themes: 

●● Here they found themselves year after year [...] drawn together by a rather implausible allegiance—not so much to Miss Marsalles as to the ceremonies of their childhood, to a more exacting pattern of life which had been breaking apart even then but which survived, and unaccountably still survived, in Miss Marsalles' living room. [...] They exchanged smiles which showed no lack of good manners, and yet expressed a familiar, humorous amazement at the sameness of things [...]; so they acknowledged the incredible, the wholly unrealistic persistence of Miss Marsalles and her sister and their life.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles, The Narrator's Mother, Miss Marsalles's Sister

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 215

Explanation and Analysis

As the narrator remembers what Miss Marsalles's parties used to be like, she remarks that these parties have been the same for decades, even from her mother's time as a student. Now, the narrator's mother and other women are still being "drawn together" thanks to Miss Marsalles's astonishing sameness. Each year, these women attend nearly identical June recitals because these recitals remind them of their childhoods. They feel an "allegiance" to the "exacting pattern" of the Marsalles sisters' lives and the annual parties' familiar rituals. Miraculously, Miss Marsalles's ways of living, teaching, and hosting her parties have "unaccountably still survived" one generation later for their own children to experience. The women share with one another their bewilderment and "humorous amazement" at the Marsalles sisters' successful persistence. Miss Marsalles's parties maintain nostalgic traditions and keep these women connected to each other "year after year." Through her reliable and persistent sameness, Miss Marsalles is an anchor in the women's lives. However, the narrator and these women don't regard Miss Marsalles's sameness as a wholly positive thing. The narrator deems Miss Marsalles's persistence to be "incredible" and "wholly unrealistic," meaning that it's unbelievable and shouldn't be possible. To the narrator, Miss Marsalles's ability to resist change is strange, unnatural, and off-putting. Moreover, the women don't care "so much" about Miss Marsalles herself. Instead, they care more about the nostalgia associated with her. Additionally, rather than connect with Miss Marsalles on a deeper level, these women treat her with a carefully constructed politeness through "smiles which showed no lack of good manners." In doing so, the women distance themselves from Miss Marsalles even as they remain a part of her life. Their consistency is motivated by obligation—to their nostalgia or social etiquette—rather than actual joy or genuine relationship with Miss Marsalles.

☞ But after the house in Rosedale was gone, after it had given way to the bungalow on Bank Street, these conversations about Miss Marsalles' means did not take place; this aspect of Miss Marsalles' life had passed into that region of painful subjects which it is crude and unmannerly to discuss.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles, The Narrator's Mother

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 216

Explanation and Analysis

The narrator recalls that when Miss Marsalles moved out of her family home and into a smaller bungalow, the narrator's mother and other women stopped gossiping about Miss Marsalles's financial means. Suspecting Miss Marsalles's impoverishment, they decided it was improper to talk about her suffering finances. This decision highlights the mothers' concern for social etiquette and the limitations that politeness imposes on their capacity for empathy and kindness.

The narrator says that the topic of Miss Marsalles's finances "passed into that region of painful subjects." Through this observation, it's clear that the mothers recognized the pain of Miss Marsalles's deteriorating circumstances. But instead of expressing kindness and sympathy towards Miss Marsalles, empathizing with her, or trying to help her in any way, the mothers grow silent about the problems they know Miss Marsalles is facing.

Focused on what is and isn't socially acceptable, the mothers conclude that it's "crude and unmannerly" to discuss Miss Marsalles's struggles. In other words, they believe it's impolite to acknowledge the hardships Miss Marsalles is experiencing. Because of their preoccupation with politeness, the mothers classify Miss Marsalles's impoverishment as a stigmatized, shameful, and taboo topic. Their unwillingness to address Miss Marsalles's hardships keeps such aspects of Miss Marsalles's life invisible. As a result, the mothers force Miss Marsalles to struggle on her own in silence and without social support.

☞ "Oh well I feel kind of sorry for a couple of old ladies like them. They're a couple of babies, the pair."

Related Characters: Mrs. Clegg (speaker), Miss Marsalles, Miss Marsalles's Sister

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 218

Explanation and Analysis

After introducing herself to the narrator's mother at Miss

Marsalles's party, Mrs. Clegg explains that she sometimes helps take care of Miss Marsalles's bedridden sister. She says she does so because she feels "kind of sorry" for the two elderly women. Here, Mrs. Clegg's words indicate that her sympathy for the Marsalles sisters is shallow. She only "kind of" pities the sisters, and this pity is her only motivation to help them, rather than genuine empathy or selfless compassion. Even more condescendingly, she calls the Marsalles sisters "a couple of babies," implying that they require her charity because they can't do anything for themselves. With this statement, Mrs. Clegg infantilizes the older women and props herself up as superior to them. This infantilization is disrespectful and dehumanizing. Furthermore, Mrs. Clegg expresses her patronizing attitude toward the Marsalles sisters nonchalantly. Her blithe tone is dismissive of the sisters' hardships and indicates that Mrs. Clegg doesn't recognize the harmfulness of her attitude. Mrs. Clegg claims to care about the Marsalles sisters, but she contributes to their othering in society by treating them as inferior.

☞ My mother seems unable, although she makes a great effort, to take her eyes off the dining-room table and the complacent journeys of the marauding flies. Finally she achieves a dreamy, distant look, with her eyes focused somewhere above the punch-bowl, which makes it possible for her to keep her head turned in that direction and yet does not in any positive sense give her away.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), The Narrator's Mother

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 220

Explanation and Analysis

While the younger children perform at Miss Marsalles's recital, the narrator notices that her mother can't look away from the food Miss Marsalles has set out for the party. In the attempt to remain polite, her mother hides her distress at the spoiling food by pretending to appreciate the music, but she's too upset to really listen. Importantly, the bad food symbolizes Miss Marsalles's diminishing social value due to her deteriorating circumstances—old age, impoverishment, isolation, her sister's ill health, and growing social stigma for being an old single woman. Therefore, when the narrator's

mother stares in horror at the fly-covered sandwiches and melting punch, she's simultaneously being disgusted by Miss Marsalles's social inferiority. To the narrator's mother, Miss Marsalles's old age, unfashionability, lesser financial means, and spinsterhood are all as repugnant as the flies and the overwarm food.

Moreover, the narrator's mother goes to great lengths to hide her disgust of the food and of Miss Marsalles in order to appear polite. Her internal displeasure is so strong, however, that she's wholly "unable" to ignore the food and what it represents, despite "great effort." It's a triumph when she finally "achieves a dreamy, distant look" that allows her to fixate on her horror without seeming rude. Maintaining a polite facade doesn't stop the mother from feeling unkind toward Miss Marsalles or indifferent toward the children. It only encourages the mother to be insincere and ensure that nothing "give[s] her away," so that her true feelings aren't detected. Because of her excessive preoccupation with social status, the narrator's mother's dismay over Miss Marsalles's social inferiority takes up her whole attention during the recital. She's further distracted by her attempts to conceal this dismay out of concern for propriety. As a result, she can't enjoy the party or appreciate the children's performances. Politeness hinders her ability to experience joy.

☞ "Sometimes that kind is quite musical," says Mrs. Clegg. "Who are they?" my mother whispers, surely not aware of how upset she sounds. "They're from that class she has out at the Greenhill School. They're nice little things and some of them are quite musical but of course they're not all there."

Related Characters: The Narrator's Mother, Mrs. Clegg (speaker), The Narrator

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 221

Explanation and Analysis

This exchange between Mrs. Clegg and the narrator's mother takes place after the children from Greenhill School arrive at the recital and begin their own performances. Mrs. Clegg and the narrator's mother's dialogue showcases the harmful othering that the children from Greenhill School experience because they have Down syndrome.

First, Mrs. Clegg refers to the children as "that kind,"

implying that they're completely different from other people because of their Down syndrome. This language is inherently alienating, and it frames the children's differences as more important than their personhood. Second, the narrator's mother is unable to hide how upset these children's presence makes her. Her distress exposes her intolerance of difference. The narrator's mother's narrow-minded attitude is plainly unkind and hurtful. Third, Mrs. Clegg calls the children "nice little things," which is patronizing and dehumanizing. The children aren't "things," and they deserve just as much respect as Miss Marsalles's students who don't have Down syndrome. Fourth, Mrs. Clegg states that the children aren't "all there," which degradingly refers to the children's intellectual disabilities. With these words, Mrs. Clegg characterizes the children as lesser beings. Both Mrs. Clegg and the narrator's mother reveal their harmful prejudices against the Greenhill School children.

Crucially, the narrator doesn't endorse her mother's intolerance. Instead, the narrator seems surprised by her mother's reaction. When she says that her mother "surely [is] not aware of how upset she sounds," the narrator suggests that she's startled by—and even disapproves of—her mother's intolerance. Through the narrator's eyes, the mother's behavior isn't attractive but disconcerting. The story doesn't support the mother's prejudice but subtly indicates its wrongfulness.

these words may not be the mothers' own, they encapsulate the mothers' response to the Greenhill School children.

According to the narrator, the mothers understand they shouldn't be "*repelled*" by children who have Down syndrome, because "*it is not right*" to feel that way about "*such children*." The mothers also insist they aren't repelled. They don't want to appear rude or offensive, especially since they're so concerned about social etiquette and politeness. But, as the narrator can clearly perceive, the mothers *are* repelled by the children's presence.

The mothers' disrespect for the children must be palpable if the narrator imagines the mothers thinking of the children as "*little idiots*." Additionally, the mothers must be visibly uncomfortable and upset for the narrator to imagine them unable to bear the children's harmless piano playing. Moreover, when the narrator imagines the mothers angrily demanding, "WHAT KIND OF A PARTY IS THIS?" she offers an important insight into the mothers' way of thinking. She reveals that the mothers think a "proper" party shouldn't include children with Down syndrome. Instead, the mothers believe that it's more socially acceptable to exclude children with Down syndrome from the rest of society. As a result, they're indignant that Miss Marsalles has violated rules of propriety by including the Greenhill School children in her recital. The mothers' convictions about what is and isn't polite causes them to insult and ostracize people who don't fit into the status quo.

☝ My mother and the others are almost audible saying to themselves: *No, I know it is not right to be repelled by such children and I am not repelled, but nobody told me I was going to come here to listen to a procession of little—little idiots for that's what they are—WHAT KIND OF A PARTY IS THIS?*

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), The Narrator's Mother

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 222

Explanation and Analysis

As the children from Greenhill School perform at Miss Marsalles's recital, the narrator observes the women's reactions. She can't see into their minds to know what they're thinking, but she can infer their thoughts and feelings based on how they outwardly express themselves. To the narrator, the mothers' negative attitudes are so obvious that they're "almost audible." Therefore, although

☝ The mothers sit, caught with a look of protest on their faces, a more profound anxiety than before, as if reminded of something that they had forgotten they had forgotten; the white-haired girl sits ungracefully at the piano with her head hanging down, and the music is carried through the open door and the windows to the cindery summer street.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), The Narrator's Mother, Dolores Boyle

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 222

Explanation and Analysis

While Dolores Boyle—one of Miss Marsalles's students and a girl who has Down syndrome—plays a joyful piano piece, the mothers at Miss Marsalles's party grow troubled. They

wear “a look of protest on their faces,” as if they’re protesting Dolores’s musicality. The mothers feel the happiness of her music, but they reject it. They do so because embracing it would mean acknowledging Dolores’s talent. Because of the mothers’ prejudice against people who are different from them, they don’t believe—or want to admit—that a young girl with Down syndrome can be a skilled pianist. However, Dolores is proving the mothers wrong, which prompts the mothers to feel a “profound anxiety.” Their worldview is being refuted, which makes them uncomfortable. Curiously, the narrator likens the mothers’ reaction to the behavior of someone who is “reminded of something that they had forgotten they had forgotten.” The experience of suddenly remembering something twice-forgotten is disorienting and could shift someone’s perspective. In this way, the narrator indicates that the mothers feel disoriented after having their biases unexpectedly challenged.

Dolores’s music is powerful and transformative. It challenges the mothers’ worldviews, and it takes on a life of its own. It fills Miss Marsalles’s living room, then flows into “the cindery summer street.” The music is expansive, lively, and active. The mothers miss their opportunity to fully experience the delight of such music because of their prejudice. Meanwhile, in the narrator’s eyes, Dolores herself is an ordinary girl—she is a child whose humanity should be recognized and respected.

☞ [...] people who believe in miracles do not make much fuss when they actually encounter one.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles, Dolores Boyle

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 223

Explanation and Analysis

During Dolores Boyle’s beautiful piano performance, the narrator notices that Miss Marsalles isn’t marveling over Dolores’s skill as something special or impossible. Instead, Miss Marsalles seems to consider Dolores just as amazing as all her other students. In response, the narrator claims that Miss Marsalles is someone who “believe[s] in miracles” and therefore “do[es] not make much fuss” when she “actually encounter[s] one.” The narrator characterizes Miss Marsalles as someone who believes that life is full of miracles and expects to find them everywhere. To Miss

Marsalles, even the smallest, everyday joys are miracles. So, if Miss Marsalles views Dolores’s skill as a miracle, she does so in the same way she views all her students’ musical achievements as miracles, not because she treats Dolores differently for having Down syndrome. In other words, for Miss Marsalles, it’s a miracle worth celebrating for *any* child to engage with music, no matter their skill or ability. Miss Marsalles finds inherent beauty, goodness, and meaning in music and in children without prejudice. Her open-minded, accepting attitude enables her to take happiness and satisfaction from life’s small, ordinary miracles. In this way, she is able to truly appreciate life.

☞ To Miss Marsalles such a thing is acceptable, but to other people, people who live in the world, it is not.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles, Dolores Boyle

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 223

Explanation and Analysis

After Dolores Boyle finishes her performance, the narrator observes that Miss Marsalles is cheerful and satisfied, but the mothers aren’t. In fact, the mothers are upset by Dolores’s display of skill, because they don’t think such musicality belongs to someone who has Down syndrome. The narrator says that Dolores’s skill “is acceptable” to Miss Marsalles but “not” acceptable “to other people, people who live in the world.” First, this distinction implies that Miss Marsalles isn’t a person who lives in the world. The narrator suggests that Miss Marsalles is too strange and divergent from the status quo to properly belong with the rest of society. In the narrator’s eyes, Miss Marsalles exists outside of what is right and acceptable. In contrast, people “who live in the world” are so-called normal people who create and enforce normative ideas of what is proper, excluding anybody or anything that doesn’t match those notions. Second, when the narrator says that Dolores’s skill is unacceptable to everyone but Miss Marsalles, she articulates her society’s belief that children with Down syndrome are less capable and less deserving of respect than other people. Therefore, according to societal norms, it’s inappropriate for Dolores to be a talented pianist. As “people who live in the world,” the mothers at Miss Marsalles’s party uphold their society’s prejudices, which fuel their hostile intolerance of the Greenhill School

children.

☛ [...] why is it that we are unable to say—as we must have expected to say—*Poor Miss Marsalles*? It is the Dance of the Happy Shades that prevents us, it is that one communiqué from the other country where she lives.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Miss Marsalles

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 224

Explanation and Analysis

As the narrator and her mother drive home from Miss Marsalles's party, the narrator reconsiders her understanding of Miss Marsalles. Her point of view is flexible, open to change. She realizes that she can't pity Miss Marsalles anymore and wonders why. The shift in her perception is phrased as a curious, open-ended question,

but the narrator answers her own question. The swiftness of her answer suggests it's a revelation, or an epiphany.

The narrator concludes that "the Dance of the Happy Shades" prevents her from pitying Miss Marsalles. Here, the narrator refers to the title of the music Dolores performed during the recital. This cheerful music symbolizes unlikely joy. The music piece originates from an opera called *Orfeo ed Euridice* that has an unexpected happy ending, is played by the young Dolores Boyle with unexpectedly enchanting skill, and is associated with Miss Marsalles's inexplicable, persistent happiness at yet another June recital. Therefore, when the narrator says that "the Dance of the Happy Shades" prevents her from pitying Miss Marsalles, she means that the music has revealed Miss Marsalles's unlikely yet fulfilling happiness to her. The narrator cannot pity or look down on Miss Marsalles now that she knows Miss Marsalles is genuinely happy. Dolores's music serves as a "communiqué," or official message, that communicates Miss Marsalles's joy to the narrator. In other words, Dolores's music is a bridge from the metaphorical "other country" where the strange Miss Marsalles lives to the narrator's familiar world, allowing the narrator to feel empathy for Miss Marsalles for the first time.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

DANCE OF THE HAPPY SHADES

Miss Marsalles is hosting another music recital, which she always calls a “party.” The narrator’s mother doesn’t want to attend. She tries to lie and make up excuses not to go, but her excuses are flimsy and unconvincing. She thinks it’s inappropriate for Miss Marsalles to throw a party now that Miss Marsalles has moved into a smaller house and her older sister has become bedridden after suffering a stroke. The narrator’s mother also thinks that Miss Marsalles is too old to throw a party.

Miss Marsalles is hurt by the narrator’s mother’s suggestion that she shouldn’t have her annual June party. She doesn’t understand how the party could ever be too troublesome. This summer party is the only entertainment she ever gives. In a conversation over the telephone with the narrator’s mother, Miss Marsalles says she would be just as disappointed as the children if she didn’t hold her party as usual. The narrator’s mother makes a face of pity, because she thinks Miss Marsalles is the only person who would be disappointed not to have the party, but she doesn’t say this aloud. Instead, she promises to attend.

Miss Marsalles’s desire to throw another party shows she enjoys socializing and entertaining other people. However, she also lacks social awareness. Miss Marsalles doesn’t perceive the narrator’s mother’s reluctance to attend her party, and she isn’t conscious of whether the timing of her party is appropriate or not. On the other hand, the narrator’s mother cares greatly about what is and isn’t socially acceptable. In the narrator’s mother’s eyes, Miss Marsalles’s impoverishment, old age, and attachment to her older ailing sister all diminish her social value. Therefore, Miss Marsalles is less fit for hosting festivities and socializing with her community, according to the narrator’s mother. Although the narrator’s mother wants to be polite, she is unkind to Miss Marsalles. She lies, and she insinuates that Miss Marsalles shouldn’t participate in society as she used to because her circumstances are deteriorating.



Miss Marsalles views her parties only positively, demonstrating her cheerful outlook. At the same time, how she regards her parties also indicates her lack of social awareness. Miss Marsalles can’t comprehend the narrator’s mother’s perspective that the parties might not be so fun for other people. Miss Marsalles is preoccupied with continuing her traditions. She wants to hold her annual party just as she has always done in the past, regardless of her circumstances or what other people think. The narrator’s mother isn’t empathetic to Miss Marsalles. She promises to attend the party but only out of obligation to the rules of social etiquette—not because she understands what Miss Marsalles’s parties mean to her. Moreover, the narrator’s mother pities Miss Marsalles. This pity is condescending because the narrator’s mother thinks Miss Marsalles is socially inferior to her.



The narrator's mother calls her friend Marg French on the phone. Both women are former students of Miss Marsalles, a music teacher, and now they take their own daughters to lessons with Miss Marsalles. The narrator's mother and Marg complain about having to attend yet another party and agree to go together to make the experience more tolerable. They recall the last two parties, which were messy and cramped. Two years ago, it rained, and the guests were crammed in a small living room. One year ago, a child's nose bled. They admit that not all of the chaos was Miss Marsalles's fault, but they despair that the parties are so much more disorderly than they used to be.

In recent years, the narrator has worried that there might be no one else at Miss Marsalles's parties except for herself and her mother. This worry hasn't come true, but it concerns her that the only regular attendees of the parties are Miss Marsalles's old pupils and their children, who are Miss Marsalles's only new students. Additionally, every June, there are fewer and fewer students. The narrator's mother and Marg French fret about this dwindling number of pupils. They're middle-class women who have moved to the suburbs, and they fear they're falling behind current fashions. Miss Marsalles teaches piano lessons, but dancing is now considered a more favorable activity for children.

Although learning piano might not be considered very important anymore, Miss Marsalles firmly believes that all children need music. The elderly music teacher is convinced that children's hearts are pure and good, and that children naturally love good things, including music. The narrator thinks Miss Marsalles only holds these sentimental views about children because she's a childless spinster, and she notes that most parents find Miss Marsalles's insistence on children's innocent goodness bewildering.

The pact that the narrator's mother forms with her friend to attend this year's June recital together indicates that the narrator's mother finds being in Miss Marsalles's presence displeasing and even intolerable. But the narrator's mother's complaints about Miss Marsalles's parties are largely petty and superficial. Her concerns about social etiquette lead her to negatively judge her former music teacher and dread Miss Marsalles's recitals instead of being able to appreciate them for what they are. Just as she can't bear the deterioration of the quality of Miss Marsalles's parties, the narrator's mother seems unable to bear the second-hand embarrassment she feels about Miss Marsalles's social decline.



Miss Marsalles has been losing more and more students, which means that her financial situation is worsening. Having fewer people attend her parties recently also suggests that Miss Marsalles's social circle is shrinking. Suffering impoverishment and increasing loneliness, Miss Marsalles's life is deteriorating. Yet the narrator's mother isn't concerned about Miss Marsalles's circumstances. Instead, she cares more about whether it's still fashionable for young girls to learn to play piano. Similarly, the narrator worries about Miss Marsalles's decreasing popularity—but not for her music teacher's sake. Instead, the narrator fears the awkwardness of being the only girl her age at one of Miss Marsalles's parties. The narrator and her mother are both more concerned about social propriety than having empathy for Miss Marsalles.



Despite her decreasing popularity, Miss Marsalles still wants to give piano lessons to children. She believes in music's value and children's innate goodness, and both music and children bring Miss Marsalles happiness. Because she enjoys bringing music into children's lives, she persists in her teaching role and in her beliefs, regardless of her personal circumstances. Miss Marsalles is goodwilled, but the narrator judges her for being too sentimental. The narrator also portrays Miss Marsalles's spinsterhood as something that discredits her and makes her inferior. In this way, the narrator others Miss Marsalles by framing her as strange and lesser because she's an older, unmarried, and childless woman.



The narrator reflects on what Miss Marsalles's parties used to be like, back when the narrator's older sister Winifred took piano lessons. This was also when Miss Marsalles lived with her sister in their family home in Rosedale. The narrator thinks that, in those days, Miss Marsalles's parties were not bad. The sandwiches were good, even if guests had to wait awkwardly for them to be prepared. The piano performances of the recital were uninteresting, with the exception of a rare disaster. Most students were too nervous or couldn't play well, although Miss Marsalles rarely criticized them. The narrator claims Miss Marsalles is a poor teacher because she's either too affectionate toward children or because she's simple-minded. She gives excessive praise, so her students usually don't improve enough to perform well.

The narrator asserts that Miss Marsalles's parties in the old days were better because they felt solid. They were old-fashioned but had a reliable sameness that lent them their own style. Miss Marsalles and her shadowy, often-forgotten sister always looked the same at these parties. The narrator recalls Miss Marsalles's appearance in unflattering terms, noting her "kindly and grotesque" face and her ugliness. In the narrator's eyes, because they're unmarried, childless, and antiquated, the Marsalles sisters are strange, childish creatures that live outside of time and normal society.

The narrator associates the good quality of Miss Marsalles's old parties with the fact that Miss Marsalles was younger and could still afford to live in her family home in those days. In other words, the narrator believes Miss Marsalles's parties used to be better because Miss Marsalles was younger and wealthier, two factors that gave Miss Marsalles a slightly higher social standing at the time. For the narrator, the food at Miss Marsalles's parties serves as a symbolic measure of Miss Marsalles's social status. Back when the food was good, Miss Marsalles was also more respectable, and other people weren't so embarrassed to associate with her. Thus, the narrator judges Miss Marsalles and her parties based on Miss Marsalles's social position. Additionally, the narrator judges Miss Marsalles for her kindness, claiming that Miss Marsalles's tenderness prevents her from being a good teacher. For the narrator, who is concerned about social status and propriety, Miss Marsalles's kindness is a flaw.



The narrator regards the Marsalles sisters with a mix of disgust, confusion, curiosity, and fascination. The narrator's varied feelings bias her perception of the Marsalles sisters, causing her to present them as strange, unattractive others whom she doesn't fully understand. Because the Marsalles sisters don't follow the social norms for women— they remain unmarried and childless into their old age—the narrator perceives them as odd beings that don't quite belong to her world. In addition to othering the elderly sisters, the narrator also associates them with death. She thinks of Miss Marsalles's older sister as a mere shadow, and she feels as though Miss Marsalles belongs to a distant past and exists outside of time since she never seems to change. In the narrator's eyes, the Marsalles sisters are like ghosts who live alongside and yet apart from living people.



The narrator recalls that the room where recitals took place in the Marsalles sisters' family home was the same room in which her mother and other older pupils had their own lessons years ago. The stiffly formal room, decorated with historical paintings and flowers selected by Miss Marsalles, was uncomfortable but also familiar because it never changed. The narrator observes that the mothers who continue to attend Miss Marsalles's parties seem drawn to this sameness, which reminds them of their own childhoods. The mothers share amazement that the parties their daughters now attend are absurdly identical to the ones they used to attend as children, characterized by the same ceremonial atmosphere, the nervous awkwardness of the young girls, the strained politeness of bored mothers, and the persistent sentimentality of Miss Marsalles.

The narrator remembers another aspect of Miss Marsalles's parties that has remained consistent over the years. Miss Marsalles always gives her students gifts—usually vintage books that are unappealing, or sometimes games with convoluted rules that aren't fun to play. The students are always embarrassed to receive these gifts, and the mothers are embarrassed too by the knowledge that Miss Marsalles might not have been able to afford them. In the old days, both Marsalles sisters had small incomes and could afford to keep their family house. But the Marsalles sisters have moved twice into progressively smaller homes, and the mothers now assume they're suffering financially. The narrator remarks that the mothers have stopped gossiping about the Marsalles sisters' finances because it's not good manners to discuss painful topics.

Miss Marsalles has maintained the same lifestyle for a remarkable length of time. She taught piano lessons in the same unchanging room in her family house for decades, and her first students still attend her annual parties as the mothers of her new students. Long after her house decorations, clothing, party rituals, and sentiments have grown outdated and unfashionable, Miss Marsalles persists in her traditions. The narrator and the mothers who know Miss Marsalles are baffled by this seemingly impossible consistency. Miss Marsalles's inflexibility is often awkward, embarrassing, and uncomfortable for them. At the same time, however, the narrator notes that Miss Marsalles's sameness is also compelling. The women who knew Miss Marsalles in their youths, including the narrator's mother, are attracted to the familiarity and nostalgia associated with the elderly music teacher. As much as Miss Marsalles is a pitiable spinster who refuses to change, she is also an anchor in other people's lives. She draws people together through her uncompromising commitment to music and festivities, which always bring her joy.



Miss Marsalles's persistent tradition of giving her students gifts at her music recitals exemplifies her selfless goodwill and affection for children. Being generous toward her students in this way makes her happy. Yet Miss Marsalles lacks the social awareness to notice that her students don't enjoy her gifts. She remains oblivious to their embarrassment, which makes the children and their mothers dread the gift-giving ceremony instead of being able to appreciate it. Nevertheless, Miss Marsalles continues to give out gifts to her pupils even when she doesn't have the financial means to afford these gifts. Her generosity persists despite her impoverishment and the deteriorating circumstances of her life. The narrator's mother and other women suspect Miss Marsalles is suffering financially, but they refuse to talk about Miss Marsalles's situation out of so-called politeness. Instead of feeling empathy for Miss Marsalles's misfortune and striving to help her, the other women ignore Miss Marsalles's problem and treat it as a shameful, taboo subject. To them, social etiquette is more important than trying to ease Miss Marsalles's suffering.



On the day of Miss Marsalles's party, the narrator and her mother drive to Miss Marsalles's house on Bala Street. The narrator's mother swears she'll die if it rains, but it's a hot, rainless summer day. After getting lost, the narrator and her mother eventually find the right house, which is small and plain. Miss Marsalles stands in the narrow open doorway. Though the narrator initially thinks Miss Marsalles looks unpleasant and overly made up, she realizes upon approaching that the old woman looks the same as ever in her antique clothing—she is clearly happy and untroubled. Miss Marsalles greets the narrator as if she's five years old. The narrator notices that Miss Marsalles looks past her and her mother as if expecting to see more people arriving behind them.

The narrator's mother's exaggeration that she'll die if it rains demonstrates how strongly she dreads Miss Marsalles's party. To the narrator's mother, having to attend the recital is already a nuisance. The added inconvenience of bad weather would make the party absolutely intolerable. The narrator's mother wouldn't express her displeasure about the June party this way to Miss Marsalles, because to do so would be impolite. However, she readily complains about spending time with Miss Marsalles to her daughter. Politeness doesn't make the narrator's mother kind and respectful toward Miss Marsalles; rather, it only conceals the narrator's mother's internal distaste for Miss Marsalles. The narrator has her own biases against Miss Marsalles, which lead her at first to perceive the elderly music teacher's appearance as disconcertingly unpleasant. But the narrator's initial impression of Miss Marsalles doesn't match reality. A closer look reveals that Miss Marsalles looks ordinary and cheerful, the same as always. Despite living in a much smaller house, Miss Marsalles remains persistently happy.



The narrator and her mother enter the small living room, which is decorated with familiar historical paintings and flowers. The room feels crowded, but there are less than 12 people inside. The narrator's mother smiles and greets people, but she remarks on Marg French's absence. Mrs. Clegg, Miss Marsalles's neighbor, introduces herself. She was invited to the party to hear the children's music. Although the narrator's mother is uncomfortable, she acts pleasant and asks about Miss Marsalles's sister. Mrs. Clegg says the older woman is upstairs and isn't doing well. Mrs. Clegg sometimes helps look after her because she feels sorry for the Marsalles sisters, whom she views as "a couple of babies."

At the party, the narrator's mother smiles and acts pleasant. However, her polite exterior is fake, and it only masks her displeasure that she must endure the recital. The narrator notices that Miss Marsalles has tried to make her new living room almost identical to the living room of her former house in Rosedale, demonstrating her remarkable commitment to sameness. Still, this year's music recital is noticeably different. The half-house on Bala Street is cramped, and there are fewer people in attendance. These facts point to the deterioration of Miss Marsalles's circumstances, including her impoverishment and diminishing social circle. The declining health of Miss Marsalles's older sister is another factor in the deterioration of the Marsalles sisters' lives. Moreover, how Miss Marsalles's sister is treated exemplifies how both sisters are othered by society. Miss Marsalles's sister's isolation in an upstairs room illustrates how she's outcast from society and deemed less valuable because she's an older, unmarried, childless woman who's now become ill. The narrator's mother and Mrs. Clegg don't have sincere empathy for her. The narrator's mother doesn't want to talk too much about her because that would be impolite, while Mrs. Clegg is eager to gossip about her for her own entertainment. Mrs. Clegg also says she pities the Marsalles sisters. By calling them "babies," she infantilizes them and casts them as inferior to herself. Although she claims to care for the Marsalles sisters, she doesn't see or respect them as equals.



The narrator's mother becomes distracted by the sight of the **food** set out for the party. It's an elaborate spread, but the food was clearly brought out into the heat hours ago. Flies crawl over the sandwiches and cakes. The narrator's mother tries to control her dismay. Smiling, Mrs. Clegg says she tried to warn Miss Marsalles against putting the food out too early, but Miss Marsalles was too eager and didn't want to forget anything. Mrs. Clegg thinks it's a shame, but the food isn't inedible. The narrator's mother adjusts her skirt and changes the subject, since it's impolite to criticize the hostess in her own living room.

The elaborate party feast Miss Marsalles has prepared symbolizes her persistence and selfless goodwill. Even though she doesn't have the same financial means as she used to have, she still wants to provide her guests with plentiful food. Even the type of food is the same as previous years: sandwiches and ice cream. Miss Marsalles is astonishingly consistent, and she has good intentions. However, her mistake of putting the food out too early has ruined her generosity, and she remains oblivious to her guests' dismay. The spoiling food symbolizes Miss Marsalles's decaying social value, which the women around her think is repulsive and shameful but which she hardly notices. The narrator's mother is especially upset at Miss Marsalles's social inferiority—symbolized by the fly-covered sandwiches—because she cares so much about social etiquette and propriety. Filled with horror, the narrator's mother tries to conceal her feelings and refuses to speak more about the food, clearly believing it's more polite to stay silent about Miss Marsalles's deteriorating life. In contrast, Mrs. Clegg eagerly gossips about Miss Marsalles's error as she takes pleasure in the drama of Miss Marsalles's social decline.



The narrator's mother complains that Marg French isn't here despite her promise to come. The narrator is disgusted that she's the oldest girl at the party, but her mother says at least she'll get to perform last and the recital will be short. Mrs. Clegg, who smells unpleasant, gets up to check on the ice cream. The narrator's mother converses with the other women, upset by Marg French's absence. The women are all uneasy, and they want the recital to begin soon. They say that other people are rude not to come, but the heat must have prevented them.

The narrator's mother's single-minded distress that her friend hasn't come appears overly strong. Her aversion to being in Miss Marsalles's company is offensive, in spite of all her strained politeness. Additionally, Mrs. Clegg's bad odor reflects her internal unpleasantness. Mrs. Clegg is insensitive and lacks respect for the Marsalles sisters, even though she pretends to be compassionate towards them. The other women at the party have unpleasant attitudes too. They accuse other people who haven't come to the party of being rude, and they frame themselves as good and courteous people—all while they wish the recital would end soon so they can leave. Although these guests pretend to be polite, their adherence to social etiquette doesn't stop them from being unkind.



The recital begins, and the younger children start to play. Miss Marsalles and Mrs. Clegg clap enthusiastically after each performance. The mothers hardly applaud and feel relief with every performance that ends. The narrator's mother stares, horrified, at the **food** on the dining room table but doesn't want to seem rude, so she puts on a dreamy look as she pretends to appreciate the music. Miss Marsalles keeps glancing at the door, apparently in anticipation of new arrivals. The narrator notices that Miss Marsalles has prepared gifts for more children than are currently present.

It's the narrator's turn to play the piano. In the middle of her performance, a woman and eight or ten children arrive. The children are wearing a dull uniform. The narrator wonders if they're here by mistake. Everyone else is surprised and confused to see them too. But Miss Marsalles was expecting them and cheerfully welcomes them inside. There is noisy disorder and giggling as the children settle in. However, a harsh, conspicuous silence rises from the mothers, as if a disaster has occurred. The narrator finishes playing her piece, aware that her performance is unimpressive, and quickly returns to her seat.

Once the performances start, Miss Marsalles happily celebrates her students' achievements. Mrs. Clegg also enjoys the music, but the mothers don't encourage or praise their children. They only wish for the recital to end quickly. The narrator's mother is even less capable of enjoying the music. She's still distracted by the spoiling food. On a symbolic level, since this food represents Miss Marsalles's social inferiority, the narrator's mother is distracted by her disgust of Miss Marsalles's low social position. The narrator's mother's concern about social status prevents her from experiencing any joy from the children's music. Interestingly, the narrator realizes that Miss Marsalles still seems to be waiting for new arrivals, and Miss Marsalles's strange anticipation contributes to the growing tension in the story. The narrator strongly doubts more people will come to the recital, and through her eyes, Miss Marsalles appears more pathetic because of her hopefulness.



Miss Marsalles's anticipation for more party guests turns out to be justified, as more children indeed arrive. The narrator was wrong to doubt Miss Marsalles's hope, suggesting that not all of the narrator's judgements about Miss Marsalles are correct or fair. When the rest of Miss Marsalles's students arrive, they bring a youthful, innocent liveliness to the awkward party with their flurry of movement, noisiness, and giggling. Miss Marsalles invites them inside warmly. In her mind, these children belong at the recital without question. However, in sharp contrast to the children's loud activity and Miss Marsalles's cheerfulness, the mothers grow still and silent with pointed hostility and discomfort. The narrator doesn't understand the mothers' sudden antagonism. She's confused by the situation, which suggests that the mothers' reaction is unnatural and extreme. In this moment, the mothers seem excessively rude and offensive for disapproving of these children's presence.



A nine- or ten-year-old boy from the group of recently arrived children gets up to perform next. Miss Marsalles smiles at him and encourages him. As he sits at the piano bench to play, the narrator notices his distinct facial features, which several of his peers share. Mrs. Clegg tells the narrator's mother, "Sometimes that kind is quite musical." The narrator's mother is noticeably upset by these children and asks who they are. Mrs. Clegg explains that they're from Greenhill School and that they're nice but "not all there."

The newly arrived children begin their piano performances. With her usual sentimental affection, Miss Marsalles is kind to these children. Immediately, the narrator observes the children's physical differences, and it's implied in the story that these newly arrived children have Down syndrome. Notably, the narrator examines the children with more curiosity than prejudiced hostility. On the other hand, the narrator's mother exhibits clear prejudice toward the children, and Mrs. Clegg blatantly treats the newly arrived children as inferior to the others. The narrator's mother is so offended by the children's presence that she becomes visibly upset, revealing her intolerance of people that don't fit into her idea of the status quo. Meanwhile, Mrs. Clegg tries to sound nice, but her attitude toward the children is also demeaning. She patronizes them and uses belittling language to refer to their disabilities. Miss Marsalles accepts the children from Greenhill School, but the women who uphold social norms shun and dehumanize these children.



The narrator's mother and the other women seem alarmed by the presence of the children from Greenhill School. They reluctantly resign themselves to listen to more piano performances, although these are no worse than the playing of Miss Marsalles's other pupils. The mothers don't know where to look; they think it's polite to avoid looking too closely at the children, but it's also rude not to watch them play. The narrator feels trapped in a bizarre dream. The distressed mothers struggle not to feel or appear repulsed by the Greenhill School children, but they clearly are repulsed. The narrator imagines that her mother is internally protesting against having to listen to "little idiots." The mothers applaud briskly, as if to speed along the performances so they will end sooner.

The mothers are offended by the Greenhill School children's presence. They treat the children's piano playing as something horrible they must endure, but this attitude is unfair. The women's prejudice drives their intolerance of the children's existence. Importantly, the mothers' prejudice doesn't exist in spite of their politeness. Rather, their hostile intolerance grows out of their convictions about politeness and upholding social norms. To the mothers, it's polite to ignore people who are different. In other words, they believe that people who don't fit into the status quo, such as children with Down syndrome, should be kept invisible. However, Miss Marsalles has allowed these children to be seen and included by inviting them to play piano at her recital. Miss Marsalles's inclusion contradicts the mothers' idea of propriety and forces the mothers to confront their disgust of people who are different from them. In response, the mothers don't want to admit they're upset by the mere presence of children with Down syndrome. Nevertheless, they reject the children because they don't think such individuals belong in polite society. The mothers' belief in the idea of "polite society" thus counteractively leads to unkindness.



Miss Marsalles announces the next performer with an air of celebration. Her name is Dolores Boyle, and she sits down on the piano bench and begins to play. The musicality of her performance is immediately evident. The music is impossibly delicate, free, and happy. All of the children fall silent, the mothers are filled with a “profound anxiety,” and the music flows through the door and windows out into the street. Miss Marsalles smiles as usual. She doesn’t react to Dolores’s beautiful playing as a great personal triumph or a shock. She celebrates Dolores’s musical skill in the same way that she celebrates all children’s musical endeavors.

Miss Marsalles harbors no prejudice toward her students who have Down syndrome. She celebrates them happily just as she does the rest of her students. When Dolores Boyle performs, she demonstrates that having Down syndrome doesn't prevent her from being a good pianist. Dolores has impressive musicality and plays enchantingly. The music is joyful and lively, and it moves through the air as if it's alive. The music is also powerful and transformative. Dolores's performance makes emotion real and conveys it to the audience, so that her listeners can feel the emotion too. All the children fall silent in acknowledgement of this music's enlivening and impactful power. But the mothers can't accept the music's joy or Dolores's skill. Their prejudice stops them from fully appreciating the delight of Dolores's performance. Thus, the narrow-minded mothers bar themselves from a meaningful experience because they're focused on upholding the status quo. In contrast, Miss Marsalles embraces Dolores's playing as an everyday joy. Miss Marsalles is open-minded and indiscriminately kind, so she's able to take joy from small yet profound moments in life.



Dolores finishes her performance, and the music is gone. Her playing was extraordinary, but she herself is not. The narrator observes that the women are beginning to feel that Dolores’s performance was a trick and “not altogether *in good taste*.” The women believe that Dolores’s musicality is not suited to her and is even wasted on somebody like her. Miss Marsalles might accept Dolores’s talent, but other people do not. The women don’t know how to talk to—or even how to talk *about*—Dolores, so they comment on the music instead. They ask what the piece was called, and Miss Marsalles answers with its title, **The Dance of the Happy Shades**, which nobody recognizes.

Dolores is an ordinary girl, but the mothers view her presence and musical skill as affronts to politeness. The mothers' prejudice leads them to believe that people with Down syndrome are less capable and therefore less valuable. So, the mothers think people with Down syndrome should be kept away—marginalized and invisible—from society. By displaying her talent, Dolores challenges the mothers' prejudices. In response, they angrily conclude that Dolores's skill goes against propriety and is socially unacceptable. In contrast, Miss Marsalles accepts Dolores happily and is thus able to enjoy the beautiful music she creates. As someone who is herself deemed socially inferior, Miss Marsalles knows what it's like to be othered by society. Thus, she open-mindedly embraces Dolores and all her students equally. In return, Miss Marsalles experiences joy from all her students' musical endeavors. The music that Dolores plays, called “The Dance of the Happy Shades,” symbolizes Miss Marsalles's persistent joy. This piece of music comes from the opera Orfeo ed Euridice, in which Orpheus experiences unexpected joy when he successfully rescues his lover Euridice from the underworld. Similarly, Miss Marsalles is unexpectedly happy despite the struggles she faces, and—like a happy shade—she persists in her “dance” of teaching music to children and hosting parties. By doing so, Miss Marsalles experiences life not as a pitiable ghost but as a vibrant, fulfilled person.



The narrator and her mother return home. As they drive out of the city, the narrator knows they will never attend another one of Miss Marsalles's parties again. But she also wonders why they're unable to pity Miss Marsalles, as they expected to do. She concludes that it's the **Dance of the Happy Shades** that makes them unable to fully pity her. The Dance of the Happy Shades is "that one communiqué from the other country where she lives."

The events of the party spark an epiphany for the narrator. She realizes that Miss Marsalles isn't pitiable, since she's happy. The narrator was wrong to look down on her music teacher. Despite her hardships and the deterioration of her life circumstances, Miss Marsalles draws happiness and fulfillment from maintaining her old-fashioned traditions, socializing, and teaching music to children. Miss Marsalles may be othered by society, but she isn't a miserable, helpless ghost. In fact, Miss Marsalles experiences more joy and vitality than the narrator's mother because she embraces small, everyday miracles. In the end, the narrator still conceives of Miss Marsalles as living in "the other country," belonging to a strange and far-away place rather than to the narrator's world. But Dolores's music and what it symbolizes—unlikely yet persistent joy—have successfully communicated to the narrator that Miss Marsalles lives a happy, meaningful, and valuable life.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Lashbrook, Camila. "*Dance of the Happy Shades*." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 20 Nov 2023. Web. 20 Nov 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Lashbrook, Camila. "*Dance of the Happy Shades*." LitCharts LLC, November 20, 2023. Retrieved November 20, 2023.
<https://www.litcharts.com/lit/dance-of-the-happy-shades>.

To cite any of the quotes from *Dance of the Happy Shades* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Munro, Alice. *Dance of the Happy Shades*. Vintage. 1998.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Munro, Alice. *Dance of the Happy Shades*. New York: Vintage. 1998.